A Phase Vocoder Approach To Pitch Shifting

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1 Introduction

The manipulation of pitch in digital signals is not achieved by simply scaling frequencies, but through structured transformations in the time-frequency domain that reshape signals in a variety of ways.

1.1 Pitch Shifting

Pitch shifting is a desirable signal processing effect for a variety of practical reasons. Historically, pitch manipulation emerged from research in vocal processing (giving rise to the term 'vocoder' a concatenation of the words 'vocal' and 'coder') [2]. Today, pitch-shifting algorithms are widely used in music production, film, voice acting, and media. Specifically in music production, digital vocal correction tools such as autotuning rely on pitch modification techniques to adjust a singer's intonation while preserving timing and vocal characteristics.

Pitch shifting is not limited to vocal signals, however, it is also commonly applied to instrumental audio. For example, electric guitarists use pitch-shifting pedals and digital audio plugins to alter tuning without physically adjusting string tension. This capability allows musicians to explore alternate tunings without modifying their instrument hardware or spending vast amounts of time retuning extended ranged guitars. Such applications highlight the broad practical demand for high-quality, real-time pitch-shifting algorithms.

1.2 The Phase Vocoder Approach

The phase vocoder is a signal processing technique used for both time-scale and pitch modifications. This algorithm was chosen to be the core processing algorithm for this project due to the fact that the family of vocoder algorithms is known for their reliability, ability to handle polyphonic signals, and their widespread adoption many modern signal processing applications. Furthermore, the phase vocoder is a real-time algorithm, meaning it has the capability to execute, in its entirety, in an unperceivable amount of time. Hence, this algorithm, along with the JUCE audio plugin framework, will provide a basis for creating a real-time pitch-shifting audio plugin.

1.3 Outline of Remaining Chapters

This paper begins with a comprehensive overview of the mathematics needed to understand the phase vocoder algorithm. It will begin with an explanation of the Discrete Fourier Transform, the backbone of signal processing, then we will examine windowing, why we need it and what problems it solves. Finally, we will examine the Short-Time Fourier Transform (STFT) which is the core analysis algorithm used in the phase vocoder.

The next section will provide a deep intuition for the phase vocoder algorithm where the goal is to connect the mathematical concepts highlighted in the background section to the processing chain that comprises the phase vocoder algorithm. The section will be divided based on the three fundamental steps that make up the phase vocoder algorithm: analysis, modification and synthesis.

Next, we will translate the mathematical concepts built up by the previous sections into a coherent program architecture. The audio plugin will be constructed in the JUCE framework, an open-source c++ framework designed to build audio plugins and and applications,

Finally, the following will evaluate output quality using metrics such as tonality and spectral flatness (noise) will be evaluated against to test how good the phase vocoder is at modifying a given input signal.

The conclusion follows the results chapter and will primarly focus on results, future work and optimizations that can be done on this project. Additionally, this section will provide insight into any errors or unoptimized processes in this project and offer any additional improvements or next steps.

2 Background

2.1 Discrete Fourier Transform

The Discrete Fourier Transform is a fundamental tool used in digital signal processing that enables sophisticated analysis and synthesis of discrete-time signals [6]. The DFT transforms a signal from the time domain into its frequency-domain representation, allowing the signal to be expressed as a sum of sinusoids [6]. Mathematically, the DFT is defined as:

$$X[m] = \sum_{n=0}^{N-1} x[n]\, e^{-j2\pi n \frac{m}{N}} \tag{1}$$

where N is the number of samples from the input signal $x[n]$, n denotes the time-domain index, m represents the frequency bin index, n is the index of the input sequenc in the time-domain and $j = \sqrt{-1}$. Each coeffecient in $X[m]$ is complex-valued and can be expressed in terms of magnitude and phase, which describe the contribution of a corresponding frequency component to the overall signal [7].

2.2 Windowing

Windowing is a function used to isolate parts of a discrete time signal so that analysis on the signal can be performed on contiguous blocks [1]. More specifically, the input signal is

multiplied by a windowing function whose domain is nonzero for a particular range. This results in a small localized snapshot of the input signal, and every other value outside of the windows domain is reduced to zero [9]. Figure 1 below demonstrates the functionality of a window function.

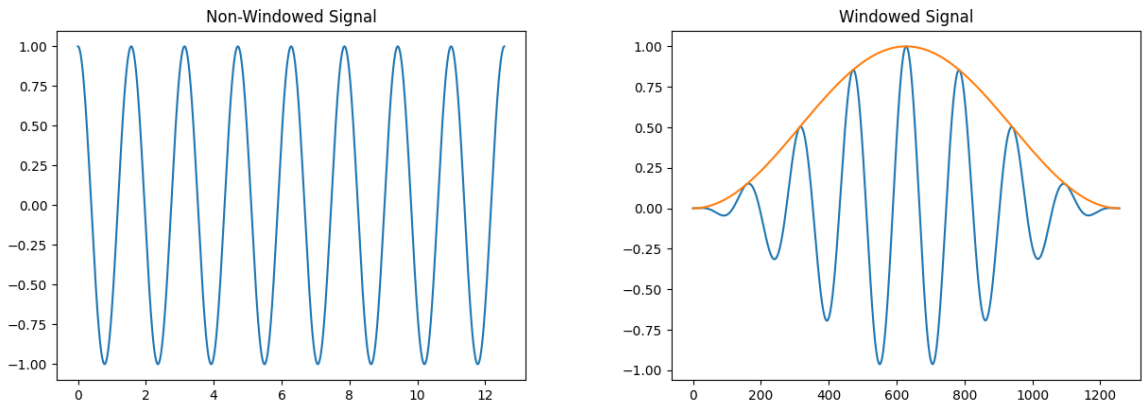

Figure 1: After applying a window function (highlighted by the orange cosine curve), the signal is tapered at the edges, resulting in a temporally localized signal.

As dipicted by Figure 1, after applying the window function to the example signal, the edges of the signal tend toward zero. In this example, the Hanning window function was used to shape the signal, however, there are multiple windowing functions such as the Rectangle window function, Triangle window function and Hamming window function [7]

2.3 Short-Time Fourier Transform

The Short-Time Fourier Transform (STFT) is a time-frequency representation used to compute the DFT of contiguous windowed segments of a signal. This is accomplished by multiplying the signal by a windowing function so that only a small portion of the signal is nonzero [2]. Mathematically, it is similar to equation (1) but with a few modifications: the addition of a windowing function, the domain of the input signal, and how the output is interpreted. Below is the STFT:

$$X[m,k] = \sum_{n=0}^{N-1} x[n+kH]w[n]e^{-2\pi jmn/N} \tag{2}$$

Where $X[m,k]$ is the 2-dimensional output array indexed by both frequency bin and time frame and $x[n+kH]$ is the section of the input signal determined by frame index and hop size [9]. The outcome of the STFT is a representation that transforms a signal from the time domain to the frequency domain. In this form, the signal's frequency components can be systematically modified and recombined to reconstruct a new signal.

3 Related Works

3.1 Classical Phase Vocoder Approaches

Pitch-shifting has been approached by a number of time–frequency methods. Early methods, such as Dolson's (1986), employed the use of the Short-Time Fourier Transform in conjunction with the phase vocoder algorithm. In particular, Dolson describes a pitch-shifting method that relies on time-scale manipulation to modify the pitch of a given signal [2]. For example, by stretching a signal, making it longer in the time domain, and then rescaling it back to its original length, the overall frequency content of the signal is effectively decreased, which corresponds to lowering the signal's pitch. Dolson acknowledges, however, that this approach is imperfect: specific constraints must be enforced when performing a pitch shift, as failing to do so may introduce unwanted artifacts into the signal or result in a reconstructed signal that has lost information [2]. While effective for monophonic (single note) pitch scaling, this classical time-scale modification framework treats spectral bins independently, which can lead to phase incoherence and unwanted artifacts. These limitations motivated subsequent refinements to the phase vocoder algorithm.

3.2 Phase Vocoder Optimizations

Unlike the original process chain described by Dolson (1986), which applies a uniform scaling factor to all spectral components, later work by Laroche and Dolson (1999) introduces refinements that improve frequency coherence [4]. In particular, they highlight a new peak-detection paradigm, where peaks refer to how much a particular frequency is in the input signal. Once the peaks are detected, they can be shifted around by a pitch-factor and unlike the version described by Dolson (1986), the pitch-factor is not restricted to an integer amount [4].

In addition to optimizing frequency resolution, modern implementations of the phase vocoder shift away from the standard two-step timescale and resample approach and adopt an analysis and resynthesis paradigm [3]. The new approach leverages phase information obtained from the STFT step to more accurately reconstruct the modified signal [3]. More specifically, a phase adjustment value can be derived from the frequency bins across two frames and when added to the original frequency approximation the accuracy of the frequency estimation is increased [5].

3.3 Alternative Pitch-Shifting Methods

The prior sections highlight the phase vocoder approach to pitch-shifting, a frequency-domain algorithm that converts a signal from the time domain to the frequency domain to compute the pitch shift. An alternative approach uses time-scale modification (TSM) algorithms, which operate entirely in the time domain [8]. Since TSM algorithms are more naturally suited to speed changes, they typically require a resample step to restore the modified signal to its original duration [8]. These algorithms must incorporate a resmaple step inorder to convert the modified signal back to the original signal's duration [8].

4 Methodology

5 Results

6 Conclusion

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